Big Butt Girls, Hard-Headed Women

By Rhodessa Jones

GIRL: (Pg 364-365) *(In the voice of the girlchild, reminiscent of a "jump rope rhyme")*
Milkshake, milkshake, cream of tartar
Tell me the name of her sweethearter

(A la Aretha Franklin's Respect)*
What you want
Somebody got
What you need
You know I got it

(She dances suggestively-hands on hips)
I got it. I got it. I got it.
Git it, Girl! Gon girl!

(She freezes into a position of fatherly authority and speaks)
Git in the house! Git yo' big butt in the house!!!

(The girl-child whines) But I wasn't doin' nothin' . . . nothin', nothin'. I ain't nothin'.

INTRODUCTION

At a time when poor black women were represented in the media and in American politics as parasitic "welfare queens," "crack whores" and prostitutes incapable and undesiring of anything other than a life of crime, Rhodessa Jones was working with incarcerated women at the San Francisco County jail. She learned much about how Regina, Mama Pearl and Doris came to be there and how they did their time. The portraits she creates of these real women demonstrate that there is more to being a criminal than simply being black, and more to humanity than what power and authority allow.

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GIRL: (Pg 365-366) *(Assuming the attitude and posture of an adolescent girl, trying to be a grown woman)* Hey, Tony! Hey, Jerry! *(Over her shoulder, conspiratorially)* Girl, that looks like Tony and Jerry. Let's go to the sto'. *(She circles downstage, ending with her back to the audience. She mimes necking, heavy breathing, childish groping)* I love you. Nobody does it like you do. Just kiss me.

(In a masculine voice) Is it good? Tell me that it's good.

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(Scenario evolves from passion to labor to childbirth ending with the girl-child facing the audience holding a baby. She freezes into a position of motherly authority)

Git in the house. Git yo' big butt in the house. Don't be so hard-headed. Haven't you done enough?!

(She whines) But I wasn't doin' nothin' . . . nothin', nothin'. I ain't nothin'.

(She moves into a frenzied dance of self defense . . . Warding off blows while holding the baby)

You better stop, Jerry. I'ma tell my daddy. Stop!

(She mimes being punched in the stomach, knocked to the ground and sexually assaulted. She rolls to her side and assumes the voice of authority)

Git in the house. Git yo' big butt in the house. A hard head makes a soft a**

(Rising from the floor. It is painful) But I wasn't doin' nothin' . . .

(Sound of a car horn. She beckons in a pleading voice) Hey, you! You wanna kiss me? Yeah, kiss me, kiss me.

(Sirens and suddenly she's handcuffed and struggling, caught) Take yo' hands off me. I wasn't doin' nothin'. Regina, call my mother. Tell her they takin' me to jail, girl. Take yo' hands offa me! Doris, tell my grandmama they takin' me to jail, girl, and I wasn't doin' nothin'.

********Scene Change********

ARTIST: **(Pg 366-367)** *(Prison)* Good morning. I am Rhodessa Jones from the California Arts Council. I will be teaching aerobics here every Wednesday morning. My pass is newly issued. You got to run a check? Look, Sergeant, why would I want to break ***into*** jail? Whoa -- It's not that I'm trying to be a wiseass. I just have no great need to sneak into jail first thing on a Wednesday morning! Oh, this? This is my beat box. These are my tapes. Here. I'd love to discuss it with you, but I've got a class to teach. I beg your pardon? Read my lips: I have far better thangs to do with my time than sneaking into jail first thing in the morning. Could I have my pass please?! *(Scene change. She is on the aerobics platform, overly enthusiastic)*

Good morning, Ladies. We're going to begin with some windmills. Now everybody smile, and one. . . two. . . C'mon Latoya, you too. All right good. . . And now for all you big butt

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girls, that's right, we gon' do some booty building this morning! What's the use of having a big ol' butt that you can't use. You know, to express yo' self. You know, a butt that commands attention. . . One that stands alone. Let's begin by tightening up with some lunges, and press one. . . two. . . *(She freezes. Scene change. She steps foward addressing the audience)*

In jail. A black, woman artist, working in jail. I look out at all those faces. There's my mother's face, my sister's face and my daughter's face. And I'm wondering how in the ***hell*** did they get here in the first place. And I realize that it is but for a flip of fate that it could be me in here and she out there.

(Scene change - she moves as though she's catching bodies falling from the air. It is sporadic. She calls out simultaneously)

Vanessa! Jeanita! Paula! Beverly! *(stops and spouts statistics)*

85% of all women incarcerated in U.S. penal institutions are women of color.

Donna! Naomi! Paulette! Jessica!

50% are African American women. It is a revolving door. And how can I, as one woman artist, make a difference, provide a supportive environment in the face of women who know that it's so goddamn hard to live anyway. Women with no jobs, who've lost their children. How do we counter life-threatening situations such as alcoholism, drug addictions, sexual abuse? How do we discuss and explore the reality of AIDS, coming to grips with the fact that screams: "Women die far faster from it"?

(Scene change. She returns to the aerobics platform) Today we're going to work with the mask -- in theatre your face is the mask. Let's begin by stretching the face. Big face. Little face. C'mon -- it is an anti-aging device. Now, use the tongue. Stretch to the side. . . To the top. . .To the other side. . . All you working girls, pay attention.

(softly to audience) So many faces. . . So many masks. . . So many stories. . .

********Scene Change********

REGINA BROWN: (Pg 368) *(an African-American woman of about thirty. Strong and aggressive)*

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I learned early, a man or a woman ain't nothin' but a plaything. I tell them all, "It's like the lotto, Baby. You got to be in it to win it." Later for all that "Ooh, Baby" this and "Ooh, Baby" that. I believe in action, so you best get on with the A team. Like Tyrone, he's in love with me, always has been, and I can understand that. But I told him, "I was born a full-grown woman, and it ain't about 'my woman this' and 'my woman that.' I'm my own woman." But, like a lot of men, he don't want to listen. Wanted to control me . . . thought he was my daddy. My daddy is dead, Baby. And my mama raised me to be strong and on my own. He got all mad, 'cause he wasn't ready for the real deal. Brought some other girl home! And now who's crying? Tyrone. Because I'm carrying another man's baby. And that man ain't even important. The reality check has to do with me and, my baby. I am a prostitute, straight up. I decided a long time ago, wasn't no man gonna tell me what to do. I'm a full-grown woman, straight up and down. Or my name ain't Regina Brown. WORD!

******Scene Change******

MAMA PEARL: **(Pg 369-370)** *(an African American woman about seventy. She speaks with a velvet voice)* My hand to God, some of them so young . . . I've been in and out of the joint since 1965 and I ain't never seen it as bad as it is now. The young women coming and going in this day and time don't have no sense of theyself. I got three daughters. My older daughter was born deaf and dumb. She's the reason I went to jail in the first place. *(She pauses and looks around before continuing in a more secretive tone)* You see, I embezzled some money from the company that I was working at so my daughter could get special training so that she could take care of herself, despite her handicap.

These girls need somebody to help them understand that you ain't got to be in and out of jail to feel important. They got to find a reason to let go of that crack and cut loose these men that pimp them for drugs, money, cars, even a leather coat. Look at them. Most of them not even 25 yet and have the nerve to be pregnant up in here. Treat these babies the way they do. How? They will sell them, lease them to the dope man for some rock. They're flesh and blood, honey. Then the dope man, he gon get busted and then the baby is lost to child protective services. And these b****es want to cry about they babies. I got three

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daughters. You know what I tell 'em? "Take that whining and complaining someplace else."

******Scene Change******

DORIS: **(Pg 372-373)** *(an African American woman about 19. The classic girlchild with a child of her own. She sucks her thumb as she speaks)* Hey, Brittany. It's Mommy. Stay with Grandma and be a good girl. *(beat)* Mama, what did Mr. Sullivan say about when I can get out of here? I wasn't doin' nothin'. Resisting arrest?! I wasn't! I was with Big Willie when the police stopped us, ran a check on him, came back to the car and asked for some ID. I asked why. They waid I was in the company of a known felon. I said, felon or not, this is my baby's daddy. Then the white police say, "Then your baby must be a felon, too." I say, "Your mama is a felon." Then he try and snatch me out of the car. Big Willie was all over him. So the next thing we know, we down here in jail. I'm gonna lose my job and I wasn't doin' nothing.' Mama, call Mrs. Ryan and tell her I got to reschedule my GED. Remind Aunt Ossie to call Social Services. Tell them that she will keep the kids while you in the hospital, 'cause these people ain't seen no criminal activity until some of them try to take my babies and put them in a home. Give little Willie a kiss for Mommy. I love you. Bye, Mama. Bye.

ARTIST: **(Pg 374-375)** *(to audience)* Who are these women? And what are they to you? *(points to the audience)* They wear my mother's face, my sister, my daughter. And now, if I'm to believe statistics, my granddaughter? You know, working in the jails, I don't delude myself and pretend that the time I spend with these people is gonna make a whole lot of difference. Their problems are too great, too immense. Benign neglect. Alienation. Isolation. Blind rage. Living in some township just outside of Amerika.

(with hands joined as in prayer) But I was raised in a family by a mother and a father who taught me that when you're called to something too great, too immense, you can always take it to God. Now the African in my American teaches me to take it to the Ancestors. *(The Artist begins incantation)* Build spirit catchers. This is a spirit catcher for one Regina Brown, age 27. Regina Brown, murdered in the winter of 1989, after her third release from jail. Regina Brown, mother of two children, a boy and a girl, left to make it in this hard-luck place called the world. *(beat)*

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******Scene Change******

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(The girl-child whines) But I wasn't doin' nothin' . . . nothin', nothin'. I ain't nothin'.

ARTIST: **(Pg 376)** *(to audience)* How many people have ever been mugged? Apartment broken into? Had your credit cards misused and abused? Been raped? Know somebody, who knows somebody, who knows somebody . . . My point is, we're all involved here. This ain't no time to be locking doors 'cause you see "them" comin'. "They" could be "us" and you may wake up and find that you've locked yourself in and they're sitting at your breakfast table . . . the struggle continues for all of us.

GIRL: **(Pg 365)** *(She freezes into a position of fatherly authority and speaks)*

Git in the house! Git yo' big butt in the house!!!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rhodessa Jones
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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

****Aretha Franklin's Respect Music and Lyrics can be found here***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=A134hShx_gw

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